

[Return to Search](#)

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**Original Page:** 354

**Culture (OWC):** [San \(FX10\)](#)

**Region:** Africa

**Sub Region:** Southern Africa

**Field Date:** 1969-1971

**Coverage Date:** 1950-1975

**Place Coverage:** Botswana

**Section Title(S):** Epilogue

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Of course, the results were not available to me in the field, and the amount of data collected made it impossible to know even in which direction the results were going. My goal was therefore to collect as complete accounts of the women's lives as was possible. The interviews were very time-consuming and the pace unrelenting, but following the lives of the eight women over the course of two months often felt like an adventure—each woman's life circumstances unfolded with greater clarity and depth for each interview day. What I learned from these detailed interviews forms the foundation for many of the generalizations about !Kung women's lives in the ethnographic sections of this book.

[124](#)  
[Interviewing In Research](#)

These two hundred additional interviews also offered me a valuable perspective on my earlier discussions with Nisa. The content and slant of her stories were not unusual. All !Kung women, it seemed, loved to talk and joke about sex. I was still willing to talk about it, but I was not quite as interested as I had been four years earlier. I now wanted to focus on less romantic matters: on friendship, on women as providers, on child care, and on avenues for self-expression and creativity—issues that had also become more relevant to my own life.

[121](#)  
[Theoretical Orientation](#)

[124](#)  
[Interviewing In Research](#)

[831](#)  
[Sexuality](#)

Although I made it quite explicit that my work involved a broader scope than it had years before, I found conversations drifting, if not being totally diverted, toward sexual topics. Also, the women usually reported on their daily activities in a dutiful manner, but when they discussed their relationships with men—either fanciful or factual—they often expressed delight in our work.

[121](#)  
[Theoretical Orientation](#)

[124](#)  
[Interviewing In Research](#)

521  
Conversation

831  
Sexuality

A number of incidents that were separate from the interviews  355 supported this impression. One day a group of women were sitting around my camp, waiting to do some work with my husband. I sat down among them and heard them discussing something about food. The animated tones, the facial expressions, and the laughter, however, quickly signaled that sexual puns using food imagery were the real matter of the conversation. Feeling brave, I joined in, trying to match their clever banter. I must have succeeded, because the women soon started to exclaim that I had truly become a !Kung woman. Praise of my verbal skills rippled through the entire group. My dubious attempts to stop them—through further jesting—only inflamed the situation further. All semblance of conversation soon broke down amid gales of laughter.

123  
Observation In  
Research

521  
Conversation

831  
Sexuality

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